ICSE

ANALYSIS OF PUPIL PERFORMANCE

October 2025

LITERATURE IN ENGLISH

Research Development and Curriculum Division
Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations
New Delhi

OCTOBER 2025

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Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations (CISCE)

MISSION STATEMENT

The Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations is committed to serving the nation's children, through high quality educational endeavours, empowering them to contribute towards a humane, just and pluralistic society, promoting introspective living, by creating exciting learning opportunities, with a commitment to excellence.

ETHOS OF CISCE

- Trust and fair play.
- Minimum monitoring.
- Allowing schools to evolve their own niche.
- Catering to the needs of the children.
- Giving freedom to experiment with new ideas and practices.
- Diversity and plurality - the basic strength for evolution of ideas.
- Schools to motivate pupils towards the cultivation of:
  Excellence - The Indian and Global experience.
  Values - Spiritual and cultural - to be the bedrock of the educational experience.
- Schools to have an 'Indian Ethos', strong roots in the national psyche and be sensitive to national aspirations.

FOREWORD

The Council for the Indian School Certificate Examination has endeavoured to sincerely take forward the vision of NEP 2020 in enhancing pedagogy and assessments through systemic reforms. In alignment with this vision, the CISCE also remains committed to ensuring that learning is meaningful, and that assessment practices are utilised as tools for growth, reflection, and continuous improvement rather than as an exercise in mere evaluation.

The ISC and ICSE examinations have long served as the cornerstone of the CISCE's academic framework, especially in shaping the educational journeys and futures of countless CISCE students. In this context, the *Analysis of Pupils' Performance* documents have played a significant role in strengthening the CISCE's assessment culture. These reports have, over the years, supported students in understanding subject-wise expectations and in preparing effectively for the Board examinations.

Our heartfelt appreciation is extended to the Research Development and Curriculum Division (RDCD) of the CISCE for their dedicated efforts in preparing this detailed document for the benefit of students. Our sincere appreciation and gratitude to the subject-matter experts at School of Continuing Education and University Resource Centre, Azim Premji University (APU) for their comprehensive and thoughtful analysis of select ICSE subject documents. We also express our gratitude to the examiners for their meticulous evaluation and insightful feedback on candidates' performance, as well as for recommending pedagogical strategies to help teachers address common areas of difficulty.

We are confident that students, teachers, and parents will make the best use of this document by engaging with its various sections in depth and by implementing the learnings to ensure enhanced and successful performance in the forthcoming examinations.

October 2025

Dr. Joseph Emmanuel
Chief Executive & Secretary
CISCE

PREFACE

The *Analysis of Pupil Performance* document is a standing legacy of the Council for Indian School Certificate Examinations (CISCE) that aims at capturing performance trends of CISCE candidates in the annually conducted ICSE and ISC examinations. Over the years, these user-friendly and accessible reports have helped CISCE schools analyse patterns in candidates' responses to board examination papers, while also providing valuable pedagogical insights and suggestions for teachers.

Each year, CISCE undertakes this exercise of a detailed analysis of the performance of candidates for selected subjects at both the ICSE and ISC examinations. Each subject document includes the questions from the board examination along with the marking scheme for each question, enabling teachers and students to better understand the scope of the question and the appropriate approach to answering it. It also presents an infographic presentation of statistical analysis and contextualised commentaries on candidate performance with detailed insights and remedies on the errors. Towards the end of the document, a comprehensive summary highlights the topics revealing gaps in conceptual understanding, areas that candidates found confusing, and tailored suggestions to help students approach examinations more effectively.

The uniqueness of this document lies in its micro-analysis of items in board examination papers where suggested pedagogical strategies are tied to each common errors identified from candidates' answers, a strategy that CISCE believes is rudimentary in driving improvements rather than merely sharing a broad stroke macro analysis of candidate performance. While these reports are grounded in real candidate data, they also lend themselves to seamlessly to classroom action.

The Analysis of Pupil Performance document for ICSE for the Examination Year 2025 covers the following subjects - English Language, Literature in English, Hindi, History and Civics, Geography, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Commercial Studies, Economics, Computer Applications, Economic Applications, Commercial Applications, Environmental Science and Home Science. In addition to the comments by CISCE examiners, the document has also included insights and pedagogical suggestions from experts at School of Continuing Education and University Resource Centre, Azim Premji University (APU).

The subjects covered in the ISC Analysis of Pupil Performance document for the Year 2025 are - Accounts, English Language, Literature in English, Hindi, Economics, Commerce, Business Studies, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Elective English, History, Political Science, Geography, Psychology, Sociology, Computer Science, Environmental Science, Home Science and Legal Studies.

I extend my heartfelt gratitude to all the ICSE and ISC examiners who have shared their valuable comments on each question. My sincerest appreciation and gratitude to subject matter experts at Azim Premji University (APU) for their detailed analysis of the documents for ICSE subjects. I also acknowledge the efforts of the RDCD team of Dr. Manika Sharma, Ms. Parul Kohli, Ms. Lyimee Saikia, Ms. Mansi Guleria, Ms. Gunjan Khurana, Ms. Madhusree Chatterjee and Ms. Aakriti Agrawal for their commitment to ensuring the compilation of the comments and data into its current form.

We hope that the document is successful in its intended mission of better assisting our teachers in identifying areas that require focused intervention and allowing them to better support CISCE students. At the same time, we also hope that it guides our students in developing a roadmap of effective study methods for their examinations.

October 2025

Dr. Bhawna Taragi
Deputy Head
RDCD, CISCE

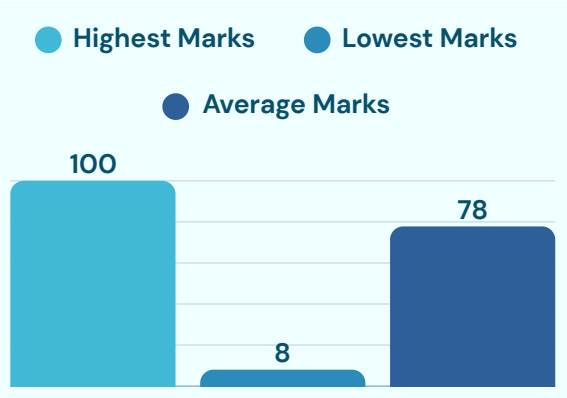
QUANTITATIVE ANALYSIS

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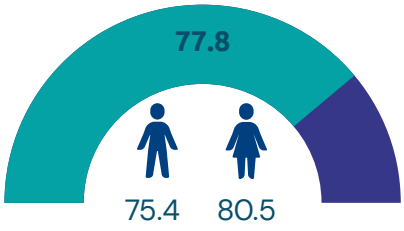
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252566

Boys	Girls
134708	117858

Maximum Marks 100



Overall Performance (Mean Marks)

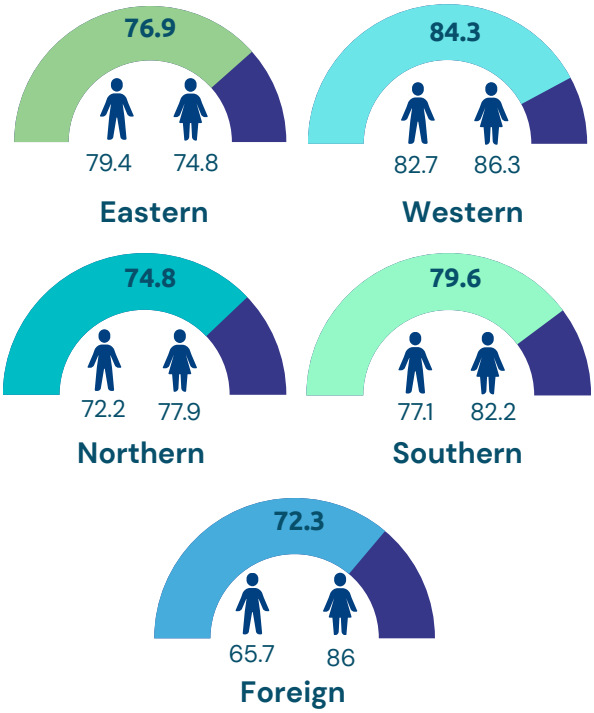


Performance by Gender

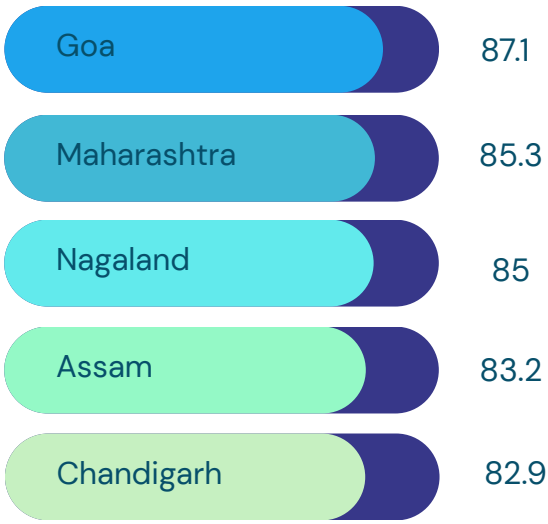
Gender	Mean	SE	t-value
Girls	80.5	0.04	81.8*
Boys	75.4	0.05	

*Significant at 0.05 level

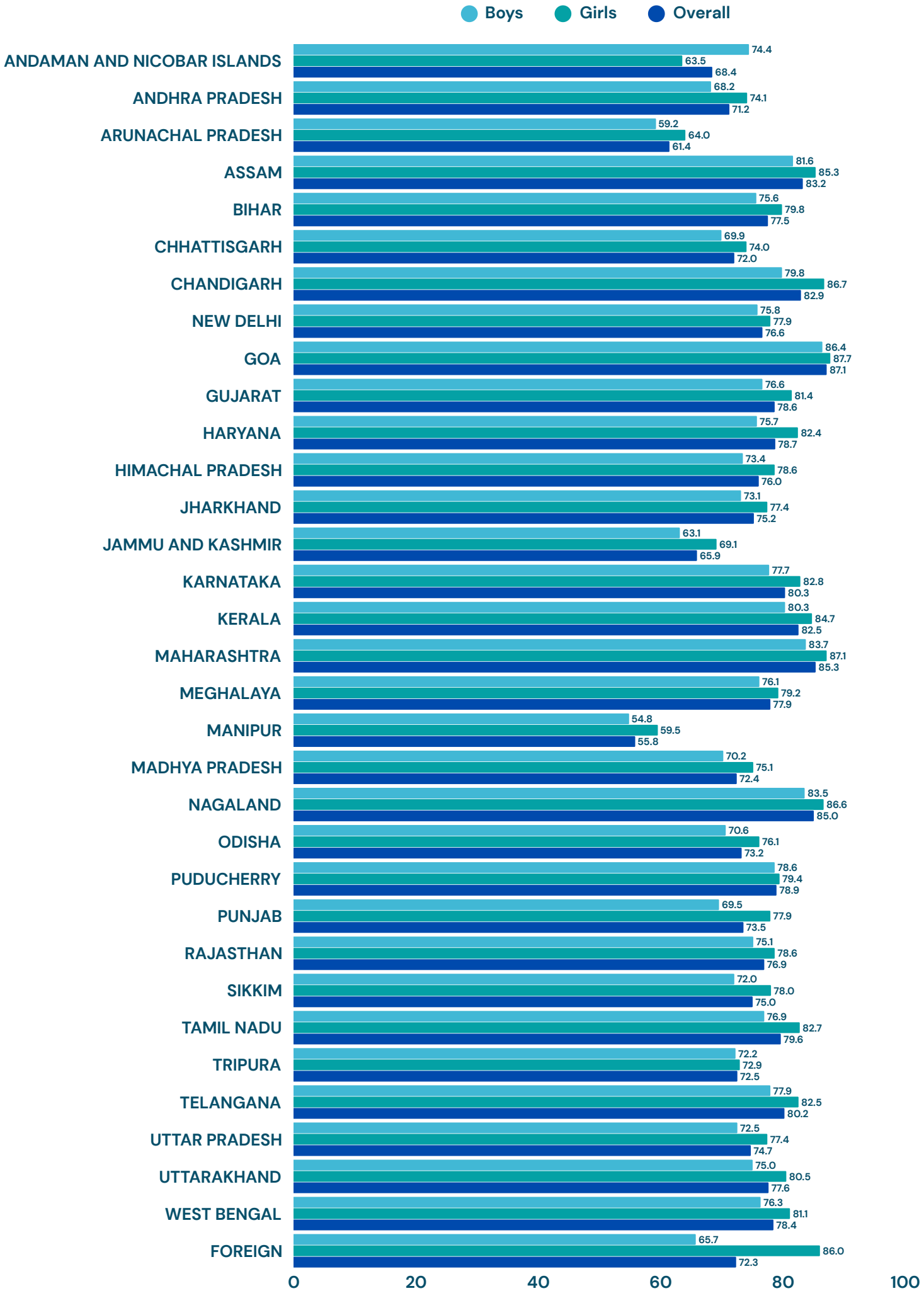
Region-wise Performance (Mean Marks)



Top 5 Perfoming States/UTs (Mean Marks)



Performance State-wise and Foreign (Mean Marks)



SECTION A

*(Attempt **all** questions from this **Section**)*

Question 1

[16]

Choose the correct answers to the questions from the given options.

(Do not copy the questions, write ONLY the correct answers.)

(i) What does Antony describe as, *'thou bleeding piece of earth,'*?

(a) Caesar's robe that was stained with his blood

(b) The blood-soaked spot on which Caesar lies

(c) The bloodied pedestal on which Caesar fell

(d) Caesar's lifeless body covered in blood

(ii) When Brutus says, *'ambition's debt is paid'*, he means that _____.

(a) Caesar's greed for power and possession had resulted in his death

(b) Caesar had left seventy-five drachmas for every citizen of Rome

(c) Mark Antony would be permitted to speak at Caesar's funeral

(d) The conspirators would be punished for assassinating Caesar

(iii) After Antony's speech following Caesar's assassination, the angry mob kills _____.

(a) Cinna the conspirator

(b) Cinna the poet

(c) Decius Brutus

(d) Cicero

(iv) When Antony says, *'He must be taught, and train'd, and bid go forth: A barren-spirited fellow;'* he refers to _____.

(a) Octavius

(b) Lucilius

(c) Lucius

(d) Lepidus

(v) Who were the members of the Second Triumvirate, formed to rule over Rome after Caesar's assassination?

(a) Julius Caesar, Crassus, Pompey

(b) Marcus Brutus, Caius Cassius, Casca

(c) Mark Antony, Octavius Caesar, Lepidus

(d) Octavius Caesar, Julius Caesar, Mark Antony

(vi) Which of the following words best describes Cassius's mood when he says:

'Come, Antony, and young Octavius, come,
Revenge yourselves alone on Cassius,'

(a) anxious

(b) regretful

(c) fearful

(d) frustrated

(vii) In the poem, *'Haunted Houses',* what does the speaker see at his fireside that the stranger cannot?

(a) the speaker only sees what is physically present

(b) the stranger can see the spirits while the speaker cannot

(c) the speaker sees both the present and the past

(d) the stranger sees both the present and the future

(viii) In the poem, *'The Glove and the Lions'*, who does Count de Lorge *'sigh for'*?

(a) The lions that ramped and roared

(b) King Francis who loved a royal sport

(c) The nobles who filled the benches

(d) The beauteous lively dame

(ix) Select the option that shows the correct relationship between Statements (1) and (2) from Maya Angelou's poem, *'When Great Trees Fall'*:

Statement 1: When great trees fall, the world is left permanently unstable.

Statement 2: In the poem, the natural world is depicted as reacting with fear and uncertainty when great trees fall.

(a) (1) is false, but (2) is true.

(b) Both (1) and (2) are false.

(c) (1) is true, but (2) is false.

(d) Both (1) and (2) are true.

(x) The poem, *A Considerable Speck*, expresses Frost's _____.

(a) love for the little organism

(b) respect for intelligent life

(c) indifference to the tiny creature

(d) anger at the mite's escape

(xi) Which of the given options contains the figure of speech that appears in the following line from the poem, *'The Power of Music'?*

And in the sky the feathered fly turn turtle while
They're winging,

(a) You're one month on in the middle of May

(b) Rainbow-tinted circles of light

(c) And life is too much like a pathless wood

(d) The wind lies asleep in the arms of the dawn

(xii) In the short story, *'With the Photographer'*, the narrator asks the photographer, *"Is it me?"* because _____.

(a) He is delighted with the photographer's skill

(b) He looks very handsome in the photograph

(c) He is unable to recognise his own face

(d) He is ashamed of how he looks in the picture

(xiii) In the short story, *'The Elevator',* which of the following does Martin's father ***NOT*** do when Martin expresses his fear of the elevator?

(a) He dismisses Martin's concerns

(b) He encourages Martin to use the stairs

(c) He tells Martin to grow up and be brave

(d) He watchesTV and ignores Martin's fear

(xiv) Choose the option that lists the sequence of events from Ray Bradbury's short story, *'The Pedestrian'*:

1. One night, as he was nearing home, he was stopped by a police car.
2. Since his answers were considered odd and unacceptable, he was forced to enter the car and taken away.
3. Leonard Mead loved to walk through the empty streets at night.
4. A metallic voice from the car asked him a series of questions.

(a) 2, 1, 3, 4

(b) 1, 3, 4, 2

(c) 3, 1, 4, 2

(d) 4, 1, 2, 3

(xv) Where was Adjoa born?

(a) Nigeria

(b) Ghana

(c) Ethiopia

(d) Kenya

(xvi) Why did M. Hamel have to leave the school after forty years of service?

(a) He was not allowed to teach French any longer

(b) He had grown tired of his job as a schoolteacher

(c) He was thought to be too strict in his ways

(d) He wanted to retire and take up farming

MARKING SCHEME		
(i)	(d)	Caesar's lifeless body covered in blood
(ii)	(a)	Caesar's greed for power and possession had resulted in his death
(iii)	(b)	Cinna the poet
(iv)	(d)	Lepidus
(v)	(c)	Mark Antony, OctaviusCaesar, Lepidus
(vi)	(d)	frustrated
(vii)	(c)	the speaker sees both the present and the past
(viii)	(d)	The beauteous lively dame
(ix)	(a)	(1) is false, but (2) is true.
(x)	(b)	respect for intelligent life
(xi)	(a)	You're one month on in the middle of May
(xii)	(c)	He is unable to recognise his own face
(xiii)	(b)	He encourages Martin to use the stairs
(xiv)	(c)	3, 1, 4, 2
(xv)	(b)	Ghana
(xvi)	(a)	He was not allowed to teach French any longer

Comments of Examiners

(i) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(ii) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(iii) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(iv) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(v) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(vi) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly. However, many students struggled with comprehension and were influenced by the distractors, leading to incorrect responses.
(vii) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(viii) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(ix) Many candidates struggled to identify the underlying connection between the two sentences or grasp the concept, leading to incorrect responses.
(x) Several candidates who understood the theme of the poem were able to answer correctly.
(xi) Many candidates struggled to identify figures of speech accurately, leading to incorrect choices.
(xii) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(xiii) Most candidates answered this question correctly, though some overlooked the word "NOT" in the question and consequently lost a mark..
(xiv) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(xv) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.
(xvi) Most candidates were able to answer this question correctly.

Suggestions for teachers

- This should be a part of the Teaching-Learning process where through formative assessment Qs, the students' ability to read mood/ detect tone/ identify character trait is built up.
- Integrate formative questions into the teaching–learning process to help students develop the ability to read mood, detect tone, and identify character traits.
- Provide ample practice in identifying relationships between two statements, such as:
  - cause and effect
  - true or false
  - contradictions
  - inferences or implicit connections
- Teach students to correctly identify common figures of speech in the poems, stories, and plays they study.
- Reinforce learning by providing multiple examples of the same figure of speech from texts beyond the prescribed syllabus.
- Familiarise students to a range of literary devices and how it can be interpreted in different contexts.

SECTION B

*(Answer **one or more** questions from this Section.)*

DRAMA

(Julius Caesar by William Shakespeare)

Question 2

Read the extract from *'Julius Caesar'* Act 3, Scene 2, given below and answer the questions that follow:

Antony: *Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears;*
I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him.
The evil that men do lives after them,
The good is oft interred with their bones;
So let it be with Caesar. The noble Brutus
Hath told you Caesar was ambitious;
If it were so, it was a grievous fault,
And grievously hath Caesar answer'd it.
Here, under leave of Brutus and the rest–
For Brutus is an honourable man;
So are they all, all honourable men–
Come I to speak in Caesar's funeral.

(i) What does Antony say he is there for? **[3]**

What does he say he is ***not*** there for?

What do you think he is actually there for?

(ii) What were the ***three*** conditions that Brutus had laid down before allowing Antony to speak to the citizens of Rome? **[3]**

(iii) List the ***three*** arguments that Antony uses immediately after he speaks these lines to prove conclusively that Julius Caesar was not ambitious. **[3]**

(iv) Antony repeatedly uses certain words in his speech to describe Brutus. What are they? Why does he do this? **[3]**

(v) Which ***one*** argument of Antony's do you think had the greatest impact on his listeners? Give a reason to support your answer. **[4]**

What were the citizens' feelings towards Antony before he began his speech?

How do their feelings towards him change at the end of his speech?

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	• To bury (perform last rites) Caesar/ to **speak** (talk) at Caesar's funeral/ mourn Caesar's death/ pay homage to Julius Caesar/ pay tribute/ last respects to to Julius Caesar • (NOT) to praise Caesar / glorify/ • To provoke/ infuriate/ incite/ instigate/ inflame/ the citizens to mutiny/ to turn the people against the conspirators/ manipulate the mob • To expose the conspirators for who they are/ reveal their true nature]
(ii)	• Brutus would speak first • Antony would say that he was speaking with the permission of the conspirators • Antony would not ***blame*** the conspirators • could speak well of Caesar • Antony would speak from the same pulpit as Brutus *[Any 3]*
(iii)	• Caesar brought many **captives** home (their ransoms filled general coffers) • Caesar **wept** with the poor • **Refused the crown** (three times at the Lupercalia)
(iv)	• Brutus is an **honourable** man • Cannot openly criticize/ speak ill of Brutus and the conspirators • To mock B/ to undermine B • To manipulate the mob • Uses sarcasm and irony to get his message across/ to prove that B was not actually honourable
(v)	Personal Response Q: Plausible responses such as: • Caesar was not ambitious (reason: he wept when the poor cried/ he refused the crown/ he enriched Rome's coffers with ransoms of captives) • Caesar wept when the poor cried/ Caesar refused the crown/ Caesar enriched Rome's coffers with ransoms of captives (reason: Caesar was NOT ambitious) • Caesar's mutilated **body** (reason: Plebians shocked/ moved by the sight) • Caesar's blood-stained **robe** (Reason: Caesar was courageous/ great General/ didn't deserve such a death) • Caesar's **will** that proved his love for the citizens (reason: Caesar was generous/ loved the people of Rome) *[Any 1]*

	• At first resentful and suspicious/ angry/ hostile/ (accept synonyms) • Later loyal and supportive (accept synonyms)

Comments of Examiners

(i) This was a straightforward question testing recall, comprehension, and simple analysis, and was correctly answered by most of the candidates.

(ii) Most candidates were able to list the three conditions laid down by Brutus. Some struggled to recall all three and managed to recall only one or two condition(s).

(iii) Several candidates ignored the word 'immediately after' and instead wrote about Caesar's Will, which is mentioned much later in the scene because of which they were marked low.

(iv) Most candidates correctly mentioned 'honourable man' as the frequently used words. However, they were no able to correctly state why Antony used these words. Very few used words like 'sarcasm' and 'irony' to explain Antony's use of the phrase.

(v) Many candidates could not respond well, as the reasoning given did not align with the stated argument. Some candidates misinterpreted the intent of the question (before and after), leading to vague or incorrect answers such as "The people favoured Brutus" and "The people turned against Brutus at the end." Instead of analysing the plebeians' reactions to Antony, several wrote about the mob or the conspirators, which was not what the question aimed to assess.

Suggestions for teachers

- Train students to read between the lines and infer implied meanings while studying the text.
- Emphasise more towards interpreting the intent and development of a character in a given text. Additionally, encourage plot analysis during discussions.
- Encourage them to note or mark important details in point form during lessons.
- Guide students to review the question paper carefully and highlight key word cues to improve accuracy.
- Help students develop the ability to construct logical arguments by pausing to understand what each question truly requires before answering.
- Familiarise students with a wide range of literary devices especially to help effectively engage with classical literary texts like *Julius Caesar*.
- Encourage students to connect the text's themes with contemporary world issues to deepen understanding and relevance.

Question 3

Read the extract from *'Julius Caesar'* Act 5, Scene 1, given below and answer the questions that follow:

Cassius: *Then, if we lose this battle,*

You are contented to be led in triumph

Through the streets of Rome?

Brutus: *No, Cassius, no: think not, thou noble Roman,*

That ever Brutus will go bound to Rome;

He bears too great a mind. But this same day

Must end that work the ides of March begun;

And whether we shall meet again I know not.

Therefore our everlasting farewell take:

Forever, and forever, farewell, Cassius.

If we do meet again, why, we shall smile;

If not, why then, this parting was well made.

(i) Why does Brutus say, *'No, Cassius, no'*? **[3]**

What conditions may force Brutus to go bound to Rome?

Brutus says, *'And whether we shall meet again I know not.'* What dothese words imply?

(ii) To what does Brutus refer when he says, *'the work which the ides of March begun'*? **[3]**

How was *'that work'* begun?

What political change would take place in Rome if Brutus and Cassius lose this battle?

(iii) Earlier in this scene, Cassius had confided to Messala a strange occurrence that he had observed when his army was on its way from Sardis to Philippi. Describe this strange occurrence. **[3]**

(iv) How does Brutus die? **[3]**

How does his manner of dying contradict the philosophy by which he had lived his life?

(v) At the end of the play, Antony calls Brutus, *'the noblest Roman of them all'*. Why does he say this? **[4]**

What does this reveal of Antony's character?

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	• In response to question posed by Cassius/was not willing to accept the humiliation of defeat/ to be led as captive/ prisoner through Rome • If they lose the battle/ defeated/ taken captive • Implies uncertainty/ unsure/ doubtful of outcome of battle/ one or the other might die in the battle/ resigned to their fate
(ii)	To free Rome of tyranny/ Caesar's power/restore liberty (freedom)/ establish Rome as Republic/ • Caesar's assassination/ putting Caesar to death/ killing/ murder • Antony and Octavius would take over Rome / second Triumvirate would be established
(iii)	• At first (two) eagles travelled with them… (perched on the ensign accepted food from the soldiers) • That morning, the eagles had fled/ disappeared/ vanished • Were replaced by ravens, crows and kites / scavenging birds
(iv)	• (assisted) suicide/ runs on his sword/ threw himself on the sword held by Strato • Stoic philosophy /accept suffering (defeat) and joy (success) with equanimity but Brutus unwilling to accept humiliation(defeat)kills himself) • Stoicism considers suicide an act of cowardice – Brutus said he was a Stoic yet he killed himself • Cato was a Stoic – he committed suicide – Brutus condemned Cato for this yet Brutus killed himself. [*Any 3*]
(v)	• Brutus was the only conspirator who participated in the assassination without envy of Caesar. • Motivated by 'common good' • Elements mixed in perfect balance • Nature would say 'This was a man!' *[Any 3]*

	• Noble – willing to recognise and acknowledge goodness / greatness in his enemy/ rival • Antony is a statesman who valued honour

Comments of Examiners

(i) Many candidates struggled to provide accurate and precise responses, leading to a significant loss of marks. Several copied details verbatim from the passage instead of demonstrating comprehension and analysis. In particular, many were unable to answer the second part of the question on "go bound" correctly, which further contributed to mark deductions.

(ii) Most candidates found this higher-order thinking (HOTS) question challenging, as it required both understanding and analysis. A common response pattern was observed, with many mentioning the assassination of Julius Caesar for the first part and the conspiracy for the second. The third part, however, was generally answered correctly.

(iii) Although this was a straightforward recall question, many candidates were unable to remember the required details to secure full marks.

(iv) Many candidates overlooked the word "contradict" in the second part of the question and focused instead on explaining Brutus's philosophy. Only a few correctly identified and explained the contradiction, resulting in a loss of marks.

(v) Many candidates lost marks in the first part as they failed to provide a complete answer. Only a few correctly identified and named the three distinct qualities of Brutus mentioned by Antony or explained why he referred to Brutus as "the noblest Roman.".

Suggestions for teachers

- Incorporate questions that promote higher-order thinking (HOTS) into regular classroom teaching and learning.
- Conduct short quizzes at the end of each scene or act to help students retain key details.
- Train students to read questions carefully, paying attention to specific clue words that indicate what is expected.
- Encourage students to highlight or mark important lines in their textbooks for better recall and understanding.
- Enable students to analyse, evaluate, compare and contrast characters and thematic inter-textuality for more thorough reading of literary texts.
- Explain every literary allusion in the play, whether Classical or Biblical, while teaching the text. Familiarise students with the complete story and discuss it in class for better understanding.
- Allow students to watch the play after completing each Act to consolidate their learning and help them grasp the sequence of events clearly.

SECTION C

*(Answer **one or more** questions from this Section)*

PROSE - SHORT STORIES

(Treasure Chest – A Collection of Poems and Short Stories)

Question 4

Read the following extract from William Sleater's short story, ***'The Elevator'*** and answer the questions that follow:

Martin felt nervous when he got back to the building after school. But why should he be afraid of an old lady? He felt ashamed of himself. He pressed the button and stepped into the elevator, hoping that it would not stop, but it stopped on the third floor. Martin watched the door slide open ...

(i) Who entered the elevator when the door slidopen? **[3]**

Describe this person.

(ii) Why was Martin afraid of using this elevator? **[3]**

(iii) What led to Martin's fall down the stairs? **[3]**

What did it result in?

(iv) How does the story end? **[3]**

Bring out the element of horror in the ending.

(v) What was Martin's father's opinion of him? **[4]**

What does this reveal to us about his father's character?

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	• The fat lady/ the lady he had seen in the elevator the previous day/ the lady in the green overcoat/ the old lady *[Any 1]* • Fat/ green overcoat / piggish face / tiny/ sharp/ blue eyes / large fleshy cheeks / no chin / mass of neck *[Any 2]*
(ii)	• Poorly lit • Dirty walls

	• Cramped/ small • felt claustrophobic/ afraid of being trapped in it • Doors closed quickly with clanging noise • Shuddered each time it moved • Old/ could fall *[Any 3]*
(iii)	• The **lady** was waiting in the elevator • Martin (terrified) turned and **ran** down the stairs • Broken leg/ fractured/ injured leg
(iv)	• Martin is alone withlady in elevator • tries to escape – cannot • Elevator door closes – fat lady pushes stop button *[Any 2]* • Cliff-hanger/ open-ended/ uncertain ending/ reader doesn't know what happens next/Martin is trapped in elevator with lady • Sinister laugh / Any other plausible reason
(v)	• Weak • Cowardly • Effeminate/ girly • Poor at sports • Afraid (of old ladies)/ timid/ scared • Foolish/ immature *[Any 3]* *(What does this reveal to us about his father's character?)* • Insensitive /lacking in affection/ compassion/ emotionally distant/ indifferent *[Any 1]*

Comments of Examiners

(i) Majority of the candidates were able to answer correctly.

(ii) Majority of the candidates were able to answer correctly.

(iii) Majority of the candidates were able to answer correctly. A few candidates overlooked details such as, 'Martin ran down the stairs/ the stairs were dark and he missed his footing'.

(iv) While most candidates successfully included the horror element in their responses, some could not explain how the story ended, leading to a loss of marks.

(v) Many candidates responded with a focus on the father-son relationship or described the father's character in general. However, the word 'this' in the question "*What does this reveal to us about his father's character?*" was misunderstood, resulting in incorrect or incomplete answers.

Suggestions for teachers

- Conduct frequent quizzes focusing on small details to help students develop attentiveness.
- Train students to read and comprehend questions carefully and to answer them precisely and to the point.

Question 5

Read the following extract from Alphonse Daudet's short story, ***'The Last Lesson'*** and answer the questions that follow:

> *"My children, this is the last lesson I shall give you. The order has come from Berlin to teach only German in the schools of Alsace and Lorraine. The new master comes tomorrow. This is your last French lesson. I want you to be very attentive."*
>
> *What a thunder-clap these words were to me!*
>
> *Oh, the wretches;* ***that*** *was what they had put up at the town-hall!*

(i) What does the word, ***'that'*** in the extract refer to? **[3]**

What other 'bad news' had the villagers received from the bulletin board outside the town-hall?

(ii) How does the narrator describe the daily bustle at the start of a typical school day? **[3]**

(iii) What was different on that morning when he arrived late for school? **[3]**

(iv) What thoughts filled the narrator's head when he heard the above announcement? **[3]**

(v) What does M. Hamel urge his listeners never to forget? **[4]**

M. Hamel writes a few words on the board at the end of the lesson. What were they?

What does he hope to inspire through his words and actions on that day?

MARKING SCHEME

(i)	• The news that only German was to be taught in the schools of Alsace and Lorraine/ French was no longer to be taught in their schools/ German was to replace French in Schools • Lost battles • The draft • Orders of the commanding officer *[Any 2]*
(ii)	• Noise of opening and closing desks • Lessons repeated in unison • Teacher rapping with his great iron ruler
(iii)	• Still/ motionless/ quiet • Classmates all seated • M.Hamel walking up and down • Teacher in Sunday best (beautiful green coat, frilled shirt, little black silk hat all embroidered; teacher only wore these clothes on special days (inspection/ Prize Days) • Village elders (former mayor and postmaster) seated at back of class • Narrator not scolded for being late • Air of sadness/ solemnity [*Any 3*]
(iv)	• Narrator regrets -having played truant - Not learning lessons - Looking for bird's eggs - Sliding on the Saar - Resenting the weight of the schoolbag - Unwilling to give up grammar and history of the saints - that he would never have a chance to learn anymore [*Any 3*] • Sad that M. Hamel was leaving
(v)	• Their mother tongue/ language/ French language/ importance of language • When people are enslaved, their language sets them free/ it is the key to their prison (*M. Hamel writes a few words on the board at the end of the lesson. What were they?)*

	• Vive la France!/ Long live France! (*What does he hope to inspire through his words and actions on that day?)* • Patriotism for country/ love for language

Comments of Examiners

(i) Many candidates misinterpreted the word "that" in the question, assuming it referred to the notice board or the crowd. Additionally, several candidates answered the first part of the question in the second part, where they were expected to mention "other bad news."

(ii) Many candidates, instead of describing the "daily bustle at the start of a typical school day," wrote about what the boy saw on his way to school, mentioning details such as birds chirping, Prussian soldiers, and other irrelevant details, which led to reduced scores.

(iii) Some candidates overlooked the phrase "arrived late," leading to vague and generalised answers. They were unable to identify the specific differences required.

(iv) Many candidates were unable to recall even three of the narrator's thoughts, despite the text providing several clear example, and thus, could not answer the question adequately.

(v) Most candidates answered this question correctly, though some failed to understand the third sub-question, "What does he hope to inspire through his words and actions on that day?" A few candidates also repeated the first part of their answer in the second part.

Suggestions for teachers

- Train students to read and understand the question fully before attempting to answer it.
- Teach students to pay special attention to detail while reading the text.
- Teach students to infer meaning from the text.
- Teachers need to point out the sequence of events in class.
- Ask practice questions to gauge the students' ability to correctly infer meaning from context.
- Provide students with relevant background information about the text and its author or poet to help them understand the work better.
- Use group discussions, debates, and quizzes to engage students in analysing characters and defending their views.

SECTION D

*(Answer **one or more** questions from this Section)*

POETRY

(Treasure Chest – A Collection of Poems and Short Stories)

Question 6

Read the following extract from Leigh Hunt's poem, ***'The Glove and the Lions'*** and answer the questions that follow:

And truly 'twas a gallant thing to see that crowning show,

Valour and love, and a king above, and the royal beasts below.

(i) Describe the scene at the beginning of the poem. **[3]**

(ii) "Leigh Hunt uses vivid sound and visual images to describe the contest between the royal beasts in the pit." Justify with close reference to the text. **[3]**

(iii) Who was the *'beauteous lively dame'* mentioned in the poem? **[3]**

What did she do?

What prompted her to do this?

(iv) Explain the following lines in your own words: **[3]**

(a) *'smiling lips and sharp bright eyes which always seemed the same'*

(b) *'the occasion is divine'*

(c) *'Faith, gentlemen, we're better here than there'*

(v) When King Francis exclaims, *"rightly done!"*, what action of Count de Lorge does he applaud? **[4]**

Why do you think the Count behaved the way he did?

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	• King Francis, nobles, ladies seated together • Watching the lions fight in pit • Count de Lorge sighing for his beloved

(ii)	• **Visual** images: Laughing jaws/ glared/ gave blows like beams/ rolled on one another/ bloody foam whisked through the air • **Sound** images: Lions roared/ stifled roar/ thunderous smother
(iii)	• De Lorge's beloved/ girl/ girlfriend/ lady love/ lover • Dropped her glove in the pit • Seeing the opportunity to test de Lorge's love/ to win attention- admiration for herself/ to attain glory/vanity • She overheard the King say, 'Faith, gentlemen, we're better here than there.'
(iv)	(a) Artificial/fake smile/ **expressionless**/ shrewd/ cunning, sharp eyes (b) The perfect/ heaven-sent/ heavenly/right opportunity/ chance (c) Safer in the gallery than in the pit (with the lions)
(v)	• Flinging/ throwing the glove • in the lady's face/ at the lady • Disillusioned/ no longer finds her attractive/ sees through her vanity/ cunning motive/ realized that this was not true love/angry with her/ • To humiliate/ shame her *[Any 2]*

Comments of Examiners

(i) Most candidates answered this straightforward recall question well, though a few wrote only "king" instead of "King Francis."

(ii) Many candidates identified visual or sound imagery but failed to include specific words from the poem, as required. A few gave broad summaries of the poem and its climax instead of focusing on the imagery.

(iii) Most candidates answered this simple recall question well.

(iv) (a) Many candidates merely rephrased the lines without analysing their deeper meaning. They struggled to explain the ideas in their own words and were unable to express their thoughts clearly.

(b) Many candidates restated the lines in different words but did not explore their deeper meaning. The word "divine" was often misunderstood, leading to incorrect interpretations.

(c) Some candidates failed to clearly explain why the King felt they were safer "here" (seated in the gallery, away from the lions in the pit) than "there" (in the arena among the fighting lions).

(v) Most candidates answered this question correctly. However, some misunderstood the question "What action of the Count did the King applaud?" and incorrectly stated that it was his gallantry in leaping among the lions to retrieve his beloved's glove.

Suggestions for teachers

- Teach students to notice and value small details in the text.
- Provide ample practice in answering similar question types.
- Train students to identify verbal cues or keywords in questions.
- Emphasise word meanings in context, not in isolation, and encourage inference and interpretation while teaching the text.
- Guide students to read and understand every line of a poem rather than relying on summaries.
- Reinforce careful reading and clear understanding of each question before answering.

Question 7

Read the following extract from Robert Frost's poem, ***'A Considerable Speck'*** and answer the questions that follow:

This was no dust speck by my breathing blown,

But unmistakably a living mite

With inclinations it could call its own.

(i) What did the narrator first imagine the 'speck' to be? **[3]**

What does his use of the words 'speck' and 'mite' tell us about it?

(ii) What was the narrator doing when he spotted the speck? **[3]**

Which ***two*** words from the poem helped you come to this conclusion?

(iii) What made him realise that he was dealing with 'an intelligence'? **[3]**

(iv) Why did the narrator conclude that the mite had feet? **[3]**

(v) Describe the narrator's initial response to the speck. **[4]**

What did he eventually decide to do about it?

Why does he make this decision?

What does this decision reveal of his character?

MARKING SCHEME

(i)	• A dust particle *(What does his use of the words 'speck' and 'mite' tell us about it?)* • Little/ tiny/ small • Insignificant/ unimportant • Living creature
(ii)	• Writing • Paper/ ink/ manuscript/ pen *[Any 2]*
(iii)	Response to stimulus: • paused suspicious of his pen • raced wildly • loathing for the smell/ taste of ink • ran terrified • crept cunningly • faltered • cowered • desperate to survive *[Any 3]*
(iv)	• Movement • Ran (with terror)/ raced/ • Crept • Faltered • tried to get away • escape death / turned to fly/ fled
(v)	• He wanted to stop it with his pen/ drop of ink • Let it lie there, till it slept • respect for intelligent life/ it was harmless/ not evil/ had mind of its own • Sensitive to life forms no matter how small/Appreciates intelligence /Respect for life

Comments of Examiners

(i) This question was generally well-attempted, with many candidates providing accurate responses.
However, some candidates struggled to distinguish between the words 'speck' and 'mite'.

(ii) Several candidates failed to adhere to the rubric of the question: i.e. mentioning exactly two words. Instead they listed phrases or answered in complete sentences.
Furthermore, several candidates selected incorrect words, demonstrating either a lack of comprehension or insufficient familiarity with key textual details.

(iii) Most candidates focussed solely on the creature's attempts to save its life and its escape from the narrator's pen, while neglecting other significant textual details ('loathing', 'smelling', 'drinking', 'suspicion') This resulted in incomplete responses that failed to capture the essence of the poem.

(iv) Most of the candidates' responses were vague, lacking precise textual references. Many candidates simply mentioned that the mite had no feet and described its frantic movement, without incorporating specific words from the text. Key descriptive terms such as 'crept', 'cowered', and 'racing wildly', which provide deeper insight into the poem were often overlooked.

(v) Most of the candidates failed to address the first part of the question, particularly regarding the initial reaction. This omission resulted in the loss of marks.

Suggestions for teachers

- Teach the nuances and shades of differences in word meaning while teaching the text.
- Train the students to read the question carefully and mindfully, and also make a note of exactly what the response is meant to be.
- Inculcate in students the habit of paying close attention to descriptive details.
- Teach students to read each question carefully and understand it before answering.
- Guide them to note exactly what the question is asking for.
- Encourage close reading of the text and help them learn to make simple, accurate inferences.
- Encourage discussions and the sharing of viewpoints as often as possible in the classroom.
- Create an atmosphere of enquiry and exploration in the class room. Encourage the students to express opinions and to challenge each other's points of view.

GENERAL COMMENTS

Topics found difficult by candidates

- **Question 3 (Julius Caesar):** was attempted by very few students.
- **Question 7 (A Considerable Speck):** was attempted by very few students
- **Question 1 (vi, xi), 2 (v) and 3(i, ii, iv):** HOTS Questions
- Questions that require a description or textual details were also difficult.
- Questions that called for analysis, the expressing of an opinion and questions that test application were a challenge to most students.

Concepts in which candidates got confused

- Differentiating between nuanced vocabulary, such as the distinction between "mite" and "speck" in *A Considerable Speck*.
- Correctly identifying Cassius' mood in *Julius Caesar*.
- Interpreting the question referring to "the work begun during the Ides of March."
- Accurately listing all three arguments used by Antony in his speech in *Julius Caesar*.
- Explaining why Antony repeatedly referred to Brutus as "honourable" in *Julius Caesar*.
- Identifying the element of horror in *The Elevator*.
- Determining whether the question in *The Glove and the Lions* required a description of the Count's behaviour or the King's.
- Distinguishing between the narrator's initial reaction to the speck and his eventual decision in *A Considerable Speck*.
- Correctly recalling the names of characters (e.g., Martin, Franz, Adjoa).

Suggestions for candidates

- Read and study the text thoroughly; avoid relying solely on summaries or notes.
- Use the Reading Time in the examination hall to read questions carefully and identify clue words that indicate what is required.
- Write only the correct letter of the alphabet for Q1 (MCQ); do not copy the statement.
- Base each response strictly on the given context.
- Express opinions on characters or themes with confidence and honesty.
- Pay close attention to details as many lose marks in failing to recall specific story elements.
- Study all descriptions of people, places, and sequences of events in detail.
- Note the phrasing of each question, especially "why" questions that require reasoning.
- Attempt only the specified number of questions (four Reference to Context questions for ICSE Literature).
- Avoid long, generalised answers; keep responses brief, clear, and focused without repetition.
- Write answers to all sub-parts of a question on a new line to avoid missing any part by oversight.
- Practice the question from the specimen papers and CFQs released by CISCE on the official website.